

CSS 1302

Persuasive Speech Planning Worksheet Complete Document & Upload to Canvas

Persuasive Speech Overview:

Persuade your audience to think or act a certain way related to a *profession-oriented* concept. Consider concepts, theories and principles that you have learned in other courses. For example, if you are interested in healthcare, you may seek to persuade your audience about a public health policy or decision regarding vaccinations. The key is to present an argument in a way that is **meaningful, relatable, and convincing**.

Goals:

The purposes of this speech are

1. **Persuade** your audience to change belief or take action regarding a topic related to your major, intended profession, or field of interest
2. Construct and deliver a clear and organized message
3. Support your claims with credible evidence
4. Deliver your message effectively and extemporaneously

Answer the following questions as you continue to develop your Persuasive Speech. You will turn this in to Canvas. As you plan for your Persuasive Speech, you should work on components of your speech in the order presented here (topic + purpose, then audience analysis, then begin constructing your content starting with the Body before the Introduction and Conclusion).

Topic & Purpose.

What is the topic of your speech? Why is it appropriate for you?

My topic for this persuasive speech is the regulation of "dopamine-hacking," which is the abuse of biological mechanisms by companies and software-engineers alike. This is a great fit for me because I'm really interested in the intersection of neuroscience and tech ethics, and it connects directly to my future goals in a professional field. Also, I qualified to touch on the topic as I have relevant training/education on the structures/pathways involved in the dopamine "reward system" of our nervous system.

Why is the topic appropriate for your audience?

This topic is appropriate for my audience because it is super relatable since almost everyone in class uses these types of apps daily. We've all felt that "brain fry" after scrolling too long or bingeing Netflix for hours at a time, so it's something my fellow classmates are well familiar with.

How is your topic narrowed to conform to the time limits for this assignment?

I'm narrowing the focus to infinite scrolls and variable-ratio reinforcement in social media apps. By sticking to these specific "brain-hacking" mechanisms (how they work, how they impact us, and how to resolve it), it should be easy to stay within the 6-8 minute limit.

Write your specific purpose statement.

To persuade my audience that we must support neuro-ethical design standards and legislative policies, like the SMART Act, to limit exploitative features used in software-engineering.

What is your thesis? Remember that the thesis should state your three main points (You may need to come back to this question after you complete the “Body” section later in this document).

With technology companies intentionally exploiting our dopamine systems to keep us hooked, we must realize that self-control is not enough to fight biological engineering; therefore, we must advocate for more policies that work to restore our cognitive autonomy

Audience Analysis.

Who is your audience?

The same as the previous speech we performed in this class. My audience consists of fellow classmates from my online Baylor “Speech” course (CSS 1302 W1). These fellow students are roughly 18-22 years old with collegiate-level education, all of whom have finished (or nearly finished) their “core curriculum” courses. Lastly, the audience consists of a variety of undergraduate majors, so I need to be careful with technical terms.”

What positions do you think your audience already holds about your topic?

A lot of my fellow classmates probably feel guilty about how much time they spend on their phones and think it’s just a personal failure of willpower. However, I would guess that an equal number of classmates are probably unaware of when this situation ever occurs to them. Due to this, I think my audience holds a “neutral” stance on my persuasive topic.

What did you learn from the Audience Analysis discussion board about your audience and their opinions on your topic?

How interested do you think college students are in learning more about your topic?

I would guess that college students would be extremely interested in my topic. I think most college students (the majority of whom are all in the same generation) all feel the same way in that companies have been allowed to operate outside the confines of law and use nefarious strategies. I also know that many other students my age currently face sleep problems and academic struggles due to this issue, so I assume that keeping their attention should be easy, and I know beforehand that they really be looking for a solution.

What information do you plan to share that is new and interesting to your audience?

I plan to build on the basics of the topic, since I think most of my audience will be familiar with “dopamine-hacking” and “doom-scrolling.” I will teach them the actual mechanisms of how our brains become hijacked, which is actually extremely interesting. I will also make the topic more relevant by revealing its eerily similar nature to the slot-machines of Las Vegas casinos. I also think the information

I share on neuro-ethical policy will be quite new to my audience, but they might find this part less interesting (its boring) so I'll have to ensure I keep their attention during this section of my speech.

In what ways is this topic relevant to your audience?

It's relevant because as future professionals and caretakers, we need to protect our cognitive health to be successful in our careers and our relationships. Additionally, this topic is relevant to my audience because the issue is becoming more prevalent, and my audience is likely affected by this issue daily. My target audience is also the age where social media use and other phone apps are greatly used, each day. Essentially, my target audience consists of the "victims" of this issue, so my solution is extremely relevant to them.

How will you customize your presentation to the knowledge and interests of your audience?

I'll mention some testimonies/stories from our fellow classmates (from the discussion board) about how this issue affects them and their academic efforts (making this personal to them and establishing the topic relevance to them, my audience). Also, I'll simplify the technical terms and hard-to-understand concepts of these neuro-biological triggers and reward pathways (since I think most of my audience is not health professionals).

Introduction.

What method(s) of gaining attention do you use in the introduction?

I'll mention some testimonies/stories from our fellow classmates (from the discussion board) about how this issue affects them and their academic efforts (making this personal to them and establishing the topic relevance to them, my audience).

How will you establish your credibility in the introduction?

I will establish credibility by mentioning my background as a neuroscience major and showing a small list of neuroscience coursework where I have studied related topics.

How will you establish relevance to your audience in the introduction?

In two ways: mention some testimonies/stories from our fellow classmates & share that ___% of people report feeling "seldom" or "no" control over their technology use.

State in full sentences the main points to be developed in the body of your speech.

First, the science of how companies and developers exploit the dopamine systems of our neurobiology. Second, the importance behind the restoration of our cognitive autonomy, and how achieve it. My third and final main point: why the current methods of "self-control" aren't sufficient, and therefore must advocate for more policy.

Body.

How will you organize your speech according to Monroe's Motivated Sequence?

1. **Attention:** Peer testimonies to their experience on the issue.
2. **Need:** The neurobiological exploitation and how it affects one's life
3. **Satisfaction:** The shift from "self-control" to policy-based solutions
4. **Visualization:** What life looks like when we have our cognitive autonomy back
5. **Action:** Specific steps to support neuro-ethical legislation

How will you appeal to logos? State one of your main points below along with one piece of support/evidence. Explain how that evidence supports your claim.

I'll cite research showing that variable-ratio reinforcement in apps triggers the same dopamine response as a slot machine (which touches on the neurobiological exploitation tactics/mechanisms). This provides the factual support that our "technology addiction" is a physiological response to intentional software/technology design (Montag et al., 2019).

Montag, C., Lachmann, B., Herrlich, M., & Zweig, K. (2019). Addictive features of social media/messenger platforms and free-to-play games: A design perspective from psychology and informatics. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 16(14), 2612. <https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph16142612>

What counterarguments will you need to address in your speech? (About the point mentioned above or another point). What is one piece of evidence you will use to refute one of those counterarguments?

The counterargument would be something like, "If you're distracted, just put your phone in another room; it's about willpower." To refute this, I'll use neuroimaging evidence showing that these apps suppress the prefrontal cortex, the very part of the brain we need for "willpower," proving that personal responsibility alone isn't a fair fight.

How will you appeal to pathos? Name one emotion you want to evoke during your presentation and the supporting material you will use to try to evoke that emotion. Be specific.

I will inspire my audience and make them feel empowered. I want the audience to feel that they deserve to be (and ARE CAPABLE of being) in the "driver's seat" of their own minds and actions. To instill both these emotions in my audience, I'll tell a story about the mental clarity and academic success a student regained once they were no longer trapped in a dopamine loop.

How will you appeal to ethos? Name something you can say during your presentation to convey your expertise/competence to discuss this topic? Then name something you can say during your presentation to convey goodwill to your audience (that you have their best interests in mind).

To appeal to ethos, I'll refer back to my background in neuroscience education, and specifically mention which courses are relevant to this specific topic (and what we discussed in those courses that would qualify me to speak on this topic). To convey goodwill, I'll emphasize my passion for neuro-ethics and medical policy, and how this is what I hope to pursue a career in. By showing that I want my career to

be on where I serve people and protect their health/wellbeing, well hopefully they'll be rest assured that I have their best interests in mind.

What steps have you taken to adapt the content of your speech so it will be clear and interesting to your audience? Be specific.

I have refined the issue to 3 simple main ideas, and down to a few easier-to-understand concepts like "neuro-ethical policy" and "cognitive autonomy" and "neuro-biological mechanisms." Additionally, I'll use visual like diagrams to show how this "reward circuit" (neuro-biological mechanism) works inside our brain. Ive also included interesting statistics, ones which should open their eyes to how impactful/serious this prevalent issue is!

Conclusion.

Restate your three main points:

We've looked at the science of exploitation, why self-control can't win this fight alone, and how we can reclaim our cognitive autonomy through better policy

How will you end your speech on an engaging/memorable closing statement?

I will share how casinos are designed to turn off parts of your brain (by the design of the building, the food/drink served, etc.). Once this is established, I'll close with the following statement: "Technology should be a tool that we pick up and put down, not a casino with no clocks. Let's advocate for a world where the exit door is always visible, and our focus is finally our own again."